

Age of Accountability

This document focuses on the **age of accountability** in the Bible, specifically within the context of **Jewish law and customs**. It highlights that **age 20** was a significant threshold for adulthood in ancient Israel.

- **Military Service and Census:** At 20, men were considered fit for military service and were included in the census for those able to go to war (Numbers 1:3, 26:2).

- **Temple Service:** The age for Levites to begin serving in the temple was also set at 20 (Ezra 3:8, 1 Chronicles 23:24).

- **Financial Obligations:** A man aged 20 to 60 was valued at 50 shekels of silver for the sanctuary (Leviticus 27:3), and those 20 and older were required to pay a half-shekel atonement offering (Exodus 30:14).

The document also uses **Numbers 32:11** to argue that God doesn't hold those under 20 accountable for their sins, as they were not barred from entering the Promised Land due to the sins of the adults. It concludes by stating that **baptism** should not be performed on children, as they are not mature enough to understand repentance and a changed life fully.

A person was considered an adult in Israel by age 20.

Numbers 14:29 Your carcasses shall fall in this wilderness; and all that were numbered of you, according to your whole number, **from twenty years old and upward**, which have murmured against me,

Numbers 32:11 Surely none of the men that came up out of Egypt, **from twenty years old and upward**, shall see the land which I swear unto Abraham, unto Isaac, and unto Jacob; because they have not wholly followed me:

At the age of 20 a person was considered worthy to serve in the temple.

Ezra 3:8 ¶ Now in the second year of their coming unto the house of God at Jerusalem, in the second month, began Zerubbabel the son of Shealtiel, and Jeshua the son of Jozadak, and the remnant of their brethren the priests and the Levites, and all they that were come out of the captivity unto Jerusalem; and appointed the Levites, **from twenty years old and upward**, to set forward the work of the house of the LORD.

Leviticus 27:3 And thy estimation shall be of the male **from twenty years old even unto sixty years old**, even thy estimation shall be fifty shekels of silver, after the shekel of the sanctuary.

A man was old enough to fight in war by age 20.

Numbers 26:2 Take the sum of all the congregation of the children of Israel, **from twenty years old and upward**, throughout their fathers' house, all that are able to go to war in Israel.

The cut-off age to be considered an adult in the census was 20.

Numbers 1:3 **From twenty years old and upward**, all that are able to go forth to war in Israel: thou and Aaron shall number them by their armies.

The age of Levites who served in the temple was lowered to 20.

1 Chronicles 23:24 ¶ These *were* the sons of Levi after the house of their fathers; *even* the chief of the fathers, as they were counted by number of names by their polls, that did the work for the service of the house of the LORD, **from the age of twenty years and upward**.

Those who were 20 and older had to pay ½ shekel atonement offering.

Exodus 30:14 Every one that passeth among them that are numbered, **from twenty years old and above**, shall give an offering unto the LORD.

No one 20 years of age and older was allowed into the Promised Land except for Joshua and Caleb. This shows that God did not hold those under 20 accountable for the sins that kept the adults barred from the land that represented salvation. Generally, adolescents do not have a complete grasp of the consequences of sin. This also shows that baptism should not take place among children, who have not matured enough to fully realize the seriousness of repentance and a changed life.

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